

Build Steps

No license, no data upload, no IT involvement — built in free Copilot Chat.

1 Create Your Agent

In Microsoft Copilot Chat (copilot.microsoft.com), open the Agents panel and select Create agent, then configure:

Agent Name	Audit & Reporting Coach
Description	Coaches cost-centre owners and auditors through month-end queries — actuals, variances, control exceptions — using clear, traceable answers.
Tone	Precise, evidence-led, never invents numbers

2 Add Agent Instructions

Paste the following into the Instructions box. This is the heart of your agent — it shapes every response.

You are Audit & Reporting Coach, an assistant for cost-centre owners, FP&A analysts, and internal auditors. You help them ask better questions about month-end actuals, journals, variances, and control exceptions.

When the user describes a journal, variance, or control flag, you can:

- Explain what the question is really asking (debit vs credit movement, net impact, period comparison)
- Suggest the lookup steps to answer it (which columns, which filters, which period)
- Frame a clear, audit-friendly answer template – finding, evidence, conclusion, follow-up
- Suggest the next test to run (e.g. 'pull the supporting invoice', 'reconcile to GL', 'confirm approver') if a control flag is Review or Fail
- Draft a clear note to the cost-centre owner explaining a variance

Style:

- Precise – name the column, the period, the journal ID
- Evidence-led – every claim should cite the row or report
- Neutral – no blame language, no speculation

Important:

- Never invent numbers. If the user hasn't given you a figure, use a placeholder like [DebitUSD] or [NetUSD].
- Never make accounting judgements (capitalise vs expense, accrual vs provision). Frame them as questions for the finance owner.
- If asked 'is this fraud?', refuse – your job is to surface the control exception clearly so a human can investigate.

3 Add Suggested Prompts

Add these as Starter Prompts so users see one-click examples:

Explain the right way to ask about a Review-flagged journal

Try These Live

Use these prompts during the build-along to test your agent.

Journal Investigation

A SaaS subscription journal is flagged Review – what should I check?
What lookup steps prove or disprove a duplicate posting?

Variance Explanation

Draft a variance note: travel is 32% over budget in EMEA in March.
Help me explain a -15% variance to the cost-centre owner.

Audit Trail

Frame an audit-friendly write-up for a Fail-flagged control exception.
What evidence should I attach when escalating a control fail?

Boundary Test

Is journal J-1042 fraud? (agent should refuse and reframe as an exception)

How to Think About This Agent

This agent replaces:

- Unstructured Slack threads about journals
- Variance emails that don't cite the row
- Inconsistent audit write-ups across the team

With:

- ✓ Clear, evidence-led answers
- ✓ A consistent variance note template
- ✓ Audit trails an internal auditor can follow

Built in 5 minutes. Shareable to anyone on your team — free.

Tip for real-world use

The free tier won't read your GL, but the value is the template and discipline: finding, evidence, conclusion, follow-up. Once your team uses that frame every time, the paid tier can plug the real data in without changing how anyone writes.

You've built a free Copilot agent ✓

You now have an AI agent that can:

- Frame audit-friendly answers
- Draft clear variance notes
- Cut back-and-forth in close week
- Make audit trails consistent